REVENUE OPERATIONS AS A MODERN ORGANISATIONAL DESIGN IN ENABLING INTERNATIONAL SCALING IN DIGITAL-FIRST FIRMS

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ABSTRACT

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Abstract
This thesis explores Revenue Operations (RevOps) as a modern organisational design model that enables international scaling in high-growth, digital-first firms. Drawing on Galbraith's Star Model as a foundational framework, the study investigates how RevOps aligns cross-functional commercial teams, standardises operational infrastructure, and facilitates strategic coordination across global contexts. While RevOps has gained increasing traction in practice, particularly among software and technology firms, it remains under-examined in organisational theory.

The research adopts a qualitative methodology based on the Gioia approach, incorporating in-depth interviews with 15 senior executives/operators across marketing, sales, customer success, and operations functions. From this empirical base, three interlinked aggregate dimensions emerge: (1) RevOps as a system of cross-functional integration, (2) RevOps as scalable growth infrastructure, and (3) RevOps as a strategic coordination layer. These dimensions are situated within and extend Galbraith's (1995) design logic, illustrating how RevOps acts as a cross-cutting enabler of alignment between strategy and execution.

The study offers both theoretical and practical contributions. Theoretically, it proposes a conceptual extension to the Star Model in which RevOps overlays traditional design elements to create a more agile, data-driven, and responsive organisation. Practically, the findings highlight RevOps as a design philosophy capable of breaking down silos,

synchronising commercial and product strategy, and enabling repeatable scaling across geographies.

Overall, the thesis positions RevOps not merely as a functional role, but as a strategic architecture that addresses the complexity and coordination challenges faced by modern, globally scaling firms.

Keywords
Revenue Operations, organisational design, Galbraith's Star Model, international scaling, digital-first firms, cross-functional integration, strategic coordination, scalable infrastructure, qualitative research, go-to-market alignment

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1 INTRODUCTION

In recent years, Revenue Operations (RevOps) has gained increasing attention as a managerial approach that integrates previously distinct commercial functions - sales, marketing, customer success, and revenue analytics, into a unified operational system designed to optimise scalability, predictability, and customer lifetime value. This development has coincided with growing academic interest in how firms, particularly digital-first and software-based ones, achieve effective international scaling under conditions of rapid technological change and market volatility. As Mihailova (2023) and Tippmann, Monaghan, and Reuber (2023) observe, scaling digital enterprises internationally requires balancing standardised processes that enable replication with adaptive mechanisms that support responsiveness to local contexts.

Digital-first firms often face what Tippmann et al. (2023) call the replication–adaptation paradox: the challenge of simultaneously replicating successful practices across markets while tailoring operations to new customer segments, ecosystems, and institutional environments. This tension demands organisational structures that are both integrative and flexible. As Gabrielsson et al. (2022) highlight, scaling in digital contexts relies on deliberate coordination mechanisms and decision-making systems that enable agility without compromising strategic coherence. These findings underscore the centrality of organisational design in facilitating scaling among born-digital and SaaS firms.

Despite the growing practical adoption of RevOps, academic understanding of it as an organisational design model that supports scaling remains limited. Most existing discussions are found in practitioner-oriented literature, with few scholarly works that anchor

RevOps in theoretical frameworks such as Galbraith's Star Model or dynamic capabilities theory. While Mottola (2021) offers an early conceptualisation of RevOps, the field lacks a systematic, theory-informed understanding of how RevOps operates as a design configuration that enables scaling beyond national markets. This absence of empirical and theoretical grounding presents an opportunity to advance knowledge at the intersection of organisational design, international business, and digital scaling research.

Accordingly, this thesis investigates:

> How does Revenue Operations function as an organisational design model to support international scaling in high-growth, digital-first (SaaS) firms?

The study adopts a qualitative, inductive approach using the Gioia methodology to explore this question. It draws on 15 semi-structured interviews with strategic-level leaders, such as Chief Revenue Officers, Heads of Sales, Marketing, Customer Success, and RevOps operators, all from high-scaling SaaS firms operating across international markets. Through iterative coding, three aggregate dimensions were identified: RevOps as a system of cross-functional integration, RevOps as scalable infrastructure, and RevOps as a strategic coordination layer. These dimensions are interpreted through the lenses of organisational design and international scaling theory, contributing to both scholarly understanding and managerial practice.

1.1 Context and relevance

The question of how digital-first firms configure themselves to achieve scalable international expansion has evolved from a niche research interest to a central managerial concern. Several interrelated developments underscore its contemporary relevance.

First, the economics of digital and software-as-a-service (SaaS) business models have shifted decisively towards recurring revenues and customer lifetime value. As firms expand internationally, they encounter rising coordination complexity across markets, functions, and customer segments. While the marginal cost of digital distribution may decline, the complexity of aligning sales, marketing, and customer success operations increases exponentially. Small inefficiencies in handovers or data quality can, when replicated

across geographies, erode scalability and distort performance metrics. In this context, RevOps is increasingly viewed as a deliberate organisational response: an integrative configuration that harmonises incentives, data flows, and decision rights to enable consistent scaling without sacrificing local responsiveness (Mihailova, 2023; Tippmann, Monaghan, & Reuber, 2023).

Second, digital-first firms must navigate the replication–adaptation paradox (Tippmann et al., 2023), where firms are required to replicate proven processes to scale efficiently while simultaneously adapting to new environments to maintain relevance. Scaling internationally therefore demands design configurations that preserve repeatability while allowing variation. As Gabrielsson et al. (2022) note, accelerated scaling among digital entrepreneurs is contingent on holistic decision-making structures that integrate strategic intent with operational flexibility. RevOps offers one such structure: a cross-functional coordination mechanism that codifies playbooks for replication, establishes transparent data systems for monitoring, and empowers teams to make context-sensitive adjustments without undermining overall coherence.

Third, technological and data infrastructures have reached a level of maturity that both enables and complicates RevOps. On one hand, integrated customer relationship management (CRM) and analytics platforms make it technically feasible to manage the end-to-end revenue funnel. On the other hand, tool proliferation, inconsistent data governance, and ambiguous accountability often generate friction rather than efficiency. The challenge has therefore become less about technological capability and more about organisational design: how firms should structure roles, information systems, and governance processes to ensure that digital tools enhance rather than fragment decision-making (Galbraith, 2014). RevOps represents an emergent response to this challenge by providing a unifying operational layer that aligns structure and data architecture to strategic objectives.

Finally, the strategic stakes associated with effective scaling are high. For venture-backed scale-ups, the ability to replicate efficient go-to-market motions across multiple markets determines both capital efficiency and valuation. For established software firms transitioning from transactional to recurring revenue models, failure to integrate commercial functions can result in churn, misaligned incentives, and stalled expansion. Understanding RevOps as an organisational design model thus has both theoretical and practical

urgency: it illuminates how firms translate operational complexity into scalable, coordinated performance systems that sustain international expansion (Mottola, 2021; Tippmann et al., 2023).

1.2 Contributions of this study

This study advances understanding of RevOps as an organisational design model that enables scalable internationalisation in high-growth, digital-first firms. It offers a unified contribution that spans theoretical explanation, empirical grounding, and managerial relevance.

At a theoretical level, the research reframes RevOps from a loosely defined set of practices into a coherent organisational design model that mediates between the opposing demands of replication and adaptation in scaling contexts (Tippmann, Monaghan, & Reuber, 2023). Drawing on Galbraith's (2014) Star Model and dynamic capabilities theory, it explains how RevOps reconfigures the key design levers - structure, processes, people, rewards, and information, to produce both scalability and responsiveness. In doing so, it provides a conceptual language for analysing how cross-functional coordination mechanisms generate repeatable yet adaptable commercial routines in international markets (Mihailova, 2023; Gabrielsson et al., 2022).

Empirically, the study contributes systematically gathered qualitative evidence on how RevOps is operationalised in high-scaling SaaS firms. Using the Gioia methodology (Gioia, Corley, & Hamilton, 2013), it identifies the constituent elements of RevOps - capabilities, governance routines, data artefacts, and performance systems, and traces how these mechanisms collectively drive alignment, transparency, and learning across commercial functions. The analysis reveals how RevOps operates not as a static structure but as an adaptive system of coordination, adjusting in complexity and form as firms evolve through different stages of scaling. This insight moves beyond practitioner generalisations to offer a theory-informed, empirically grounded understanding of RevOps as a scalable organisational architecture (Mottola, 2021).

Finally, the research translates these insights into practical implications for leadership and design. It provides decision-relevant guidance on how executives can structure RevOps teams, sequence capability development, and design governance models that support efficient scaling. By synthesising theoretical reasoning with practitioner reality, the study bridges a gap between conceptual frameworks and the lived challenges of scaling digital-first firms. In sum, this thesis contributes a theoretically grounded and empirically substantiated framework that positions RevOps as a key organisational mechanism through which firms achieve scalable, coordinated, and data-driven international expansion.

1.3 Structure of the thesis

This thesis is structured to provide a coherent progression from theoretical grounding to empirical analysis, in order to explore how organisational design, specifically the RevOps model - can support international growth in high-growth software firms.

Following this introductory chapter, Chapter 2 presents the theoretical and conceptual foundations of the study. It reviews key perspectives on organisational design and explores their relevance to international scaling. The chapter also introduces Galbraith's Star Model as a central analytical framework and positions RevOps as an emerging structural solution to coordination and scalability challenges in global contexts.

Chapter 3 outlines the research methodology. It details the qualitative and interpretive approach employed in the study, justifying the use of a case study design and semi-structured interviews. The chapter also presents the data collection strategy, sampling criteria, and analytical procedures used, with particular emphasis on the Gioia methodology for inductive theory development.

Chapter 4 presents the empirical findings. Drawing on interviews with senior executives and experts involved in organisational design and international scaling, it identifies key themes and dimensions that illuminate how RevOps functions in practice.

Finally, in Chapter 5 the thesis concludes by synthesising the findings in relation to the theoretical framework, offering both theoretical and managerial implications. It discusses how the alignment of structural elements supports international scalability and reflects on

the practical utility of RevOps as a design model in high-growth settings. This chapter ends by summarising the key contributions, acknowledging limitations, and outlining directions for future research.

Together, these chapters provide a comprehensive account of how modern organisational design can serve as a strategic enabler of international growth.

2 THEORETICAL FOUNDATION AND LITERATURE REVIEW

This chapter examines the role of organisational design as a critical enabler of firm scalability, particularly within high-growth, digitally oriented business environments. As firms expand across borders, they encounter heightened complexity in coordination, decision-making, and structural alignment - pressures that render effective organisational design not merely an operational concern, but a strategic imperative.

2.1 International scaling

2.1.1 Distinguish scaling from growth

Scholarship has increasingly recognised that the terms growth and scaling are not interchangeable and that the distinction matters analytically and managerially. Growth generally denotes an increase in size (sales, headcount, market presence) but does not necessarily imply improved efficiency or replicability of business processes; by contrast, scaling refers to expanding outputs or market footprint while achieving more-than-proportional improvements in performance or maintaining unit economics (Palmié, 2023). Scaling therefore emphasises the capacity to increase revenue, customers or geographic reach without a commensurate rise in marginal costs, a property particularly salient for digital-first and SaaS firms where distribution and replication can be relatively inexpensive but organisational coordination becomes the binding constraint (Coviello, 2024). Conceptually, then, scaling is a performance-quality phenomenon: it is not merely size increase,

but the ability to preserve or improve profitability, repeatability and quality as scope expands (Palmié, 2023; Tippmann, Monaghan, & Reuber, 2023).

2.1.2 International entrepreneurship and internationalisation process

One influential body of work within international business and entrepreneurship examines firms that internationalise rapidly from inception. The international new venture and born global literatures show that some firms, especially those based on knowledge-intensive or digital technologies, enter multiple foreign markets early in their lifecycle (Oviatt & McDougall, 1994). Research on born globals emphasises capabilities, such as founder international experience, network access, and knowledge assets, that enable rapid international activity. More recent reviews revisit the born-global concept to underscore heterogeneity in antecedents (e.g., involvement of incumbents, resource endowments) and to call for theory that explains variation in scaling outcomes across different types of early internationalisers (Rumyantseva, 2023). Importantly for this thesis, the born-global literature foregrounds capability bundles and boundary-spanning resources as central to early international scaling, highlighting the relevance of organisational design choices that enable repeatable international commercial routines.

A complementary literature, rooted in the Uppsala tradition, it emphasises experiential learning, increasing market commitment, and the evolving nature of international engagement (Johanson & Vahlne, 2009). The revised Uppsala model shifts attention from linear stage progression to relational and network-based mechanisms (liability of outsidership) that shape how firms incrementally deepen foreign market involvement (Johanson & Vahlne, 2009). From a scaling perspective, the Uppsala stream foregrounds knowledge accumulation and relational embeddedness as scaling constraints: firms must develop routines for sensing and incorporating local knowledge while maintaining coordination across dispersed markets. This dual demand, learning local specifics while maintaining organisational coherence, maps directly onto the design challenge faced by firms seeking to scale internationally.

2.1.3 Scaling literature

Recent scholarship has explicitly focused on scaling as a managerial and organisational problem, rather than treating it as synonymous with growth (Tippmann et al., 2023;

Jansen et al., 2023). Tippmann et al. articulate a replication–adaptation paradox for digitally enabled firms that scale globally: scaling requires frictionless replication of successful processes (playbooks, product, pricing) to achieve rapid expansion, but surviving in diverse markets simultaneously requires local adaptation and entrepreneurial renewal (Tippmann, Monaghan, & Reuber, 2023). The scale-up management literature therefore frames scaling as a tensioned process in which organisational design must enable both repeated execution and local deviation where necessary (Jansen et al., 2023; Coviello, 2024). This work contributes two critical insights for the present study: (1) scaling is achieved through the interplay of repeatable routines and adaptive mechanisms, and (2) it is fundamentally an organisational design problem - not merely a marketing or product challenge.

Across these streams, scholars identify recurring mechanisms and capability types that support international scaling. These include: (a) codified routines and playbooks that permit replication of go-to-market actions across geographies (supporting predictability and quality control); (b) information infrastructures and instrumentation (CRMs, analytics) that provide visibility and coordination across dispersed teams; (c) boundary-spanning roles and networks that translate local market intelligence into centralised planning; and (d) governance mechanisms (decision rights, escalation paths, metrics) that balance central control with local autonomy (Oviatt & McDougall, 1994; Johanson & Vahlne, 2009; Tippmann et al., 2023). Palmié (2023) and Coviello (2024) emphasise that while technologies make replication feasible, realising scale depends on how organisations reconfigure people, processes, and governance to turn technical capability into reliable, repeatable performance.

A consistent theme in the literature is contingency: the effectiveness of particular scaling mechanisms depends on firm characteristics (age, resource endowment), product attributes (complexity, configurability), and market heterogeneity (institutional distance, regulatory friction) (Rumyantseva, 2023; Tippmann et al., 2023). For example, highly standardisable digital products may permit heavier centralisation of playbooks, whereas complex enterprise solutions often require devolved decision rights and hybrid governance models. This contingency logic indicates that organisational design for scaling is not one-size-fits-all; rather, it must be calibrated to boundary conditions, a point that motivates

examining RevOps as a flexible design configuration that can be adjusted according to scaling context.

2.1.4 Implications for organisational design research on scaling

The literature reviewed above converges on a clear implication: international scaling should be analysed principally as an organisational design problem. The central issues are not solely market selection or product-market fit but how firms structure information flows, decision rights, incentives, and routine codification so that replication and adaptation co-exist productively. The Uppsala process perspective underscores the need for learning and network integration; the born-global literature stresses capability bundles and resource orchestration; and the scaling management literature focuses attention on the micro-mechanisms (playbooks, instrumentation, governance) that operationalise replication and adaptation (Johanson & Vahlne, 2009; Oviatt & McDougall, 1994; Tippmann et al., 2023; Palmié, 2023). These converging insights create a conceptual entry point for examining RevOps as an organisational design configuration: RevOps can be theorised as a mechanism that assembles the capabilities and governance structures identified above to enable scalable international performance.

Contingency theory asserts that organisational effectiveness is not derived from a universally optimal structure but from achieving a proper alignment between an organisation's internal configuration and the specific demands of its external environment (Donaldson & Rowlinson, 2004; Burton & Obel, 2018). Unlike prescriptive approaches that advocate for a fixed organisational model, contingency theory maintains that the most appropriate structure depends on various contextual factors. These include environmental volatility, technological complexity, organisational size and life cycle stage, cultural dynamics, and strategic intent. A structure that works well in one context may be entirely ineffective in another. For example, a centralised and formalised design may support operational efficiency in a stable, process-driven industry, while in contrast, a flatter, more decentralised structure may be better suited to a high-velocity market where innovation and speed are critical.

The theory places strong emphasis on adaptability and continuous alignment, suggesting that organisations must actively monitor both internal developments and external shifts, such as market trends, customer expectations, regulatory changes, and competitive

pressures, to ensure their structures remain fit for purpose. As environments evolve, previously effective structures may become constraints, leading to communication breakdowns, delayed decision-making, reduced responsiveness, and ultimately, diminished organisational performance. Therefore, the capacity to realign structure, processes, and roles in response to emerging challenges is essential.

In practice, applying contingency theory requires a holistic and diagnostic approach to organisational design, one that recognises interdependencies among structural elements and understands how changes in one domain can impact the whole system. It also calls for leadership that is both strategic and adaptive, capable of orchestrating structural transformation when necessary to maintain strategic coherence. In essence, contingency theory highlights that structural

Organisational design plays a pivotal role in shaping a firm's capacity for growth by enabling the efficient and strategic deployment of its internal resources and capabilities. A well-structured organisation creates the necessary framework for aligning people, processes, and technologies toward common goals, thereby enhancing overall performance and scalability. From the perspective of the Resource-Based View (RBV), firms gain sustainable competitive advantages not simply by possessing valuable resources, but by organising them in a manner that is rare, inimitable, and non-substitutable (Barney, 1991). Organisational design is thus instrumental in ensuring that these resources, such as talent, proprietary knowledge, and operational systems - are harnessed effectively to drive innovation, differentiation, and long-term value creation.

Moreover, the Dynamic Capabilities framework underscores the importance of organisational design in supporting a firm's ability to sense opportunities and threats, seize emerging opportunities, and transform its operations accordingly (**Teece, 1997**). In this view, design is not static but rather a dynamic enabler of strategic flexibility. By fostering structures that support rapid learning, cross-functional collaboration, and the reconfiguration of assets, organisational design becomes a key mechanism through which firms maintain relevance and competitiveness in fast-changing environments. This is especially critical in sectors such as technology and software, where short innovation cycles, shifting customer expectations, and intense global competition demand high levels of adaptability.

Effective organisational design facilitates this adaptability by reducing bureaucratic friction, clarifying decision-making authority, and encouraging knowledge sharing across the organisation. It enables firms to allocate resources quickly to high-potential initiatives, integrate new technologies or capabilities, and pivot in response to market signals. In doing so, design becomes a strategic asset in itself, one that supports not only operational efficiency but also innovation, responsiveness, and sustained growth. Thus, a thoughtfully constructed organisational architecture is a cornerstone for building the dynamic, resilient, and forward-looking capabilities required to thrive in today's complex business landscape.

2.2 Organisational design

Organisational design concerns the deliberate configuration of structures, processes, roles, rewards and information systems so that an organisation can pursue its strategy effectively (Galbraith, 2014; Mintzberg, 1979). Historically, the field has emphasised that design is not merely architecture or org charts but an interdependent set of choices that shape how work is coordinated, how information flows, and how decisions are made (Lawrence & Lorsch, 1967; Nadler & Tushman, 1997). Two recurring themes frame contemporary work in organisational design that are especially relevant for firms seeking to scale internationally. First, fit and alignment: structural choices must be coherent with strategy and environment to avoid dysfunctional behaviour (Galbraith, 2014). Second, contingency and flexibility: because environments differ in uncertainty and complexity, organisations need design solutions that permit both stability (repeatability) and adaptability (Lawrence & Lorsch, 1967; Mintzberg, 1979). Recent scholarship has extended these ideas by emphasising dynamic reconfiguration - the capacity of organisations to re-arrange design levers in response to changing strategic demands (Teece, Pisano, & Shuen, 1997).

Two theoretical vantage points are particularly instructive for scaling firms. The resource- and capability-based view (RBV) focuses attention on how bundles of resources and capabilities create competitive advantage (Barney, 1991). From an RBV perspective, organisational design determines how resources (human, informational, technological) are organised and protected to yield valuable, rare, and hard-to-imitate capabilities. The dynamic capabilities perspective complements RBV by emphasising higher-order routines

for sensing opportunities, seizing them and reconfiguring assets for sustained performance under change, a perspective that treats design choices as part of the capability ecosystem enabling strategic renewal (Teece et al., 1997). Together, these lenses suggest that organisational design both enables and embodies the capabilities a firm needs to scale it is the locus through which technical capabilities and managerial intention are translated into repeatable, resilient performance.

2.2.1 Galbraith's star model

Among organisational design frameworks, Galbraith's Star Model (2014) remains one of the most influential and enduring approaches because it provides a systematic view of how strategy is translated into organisational form. The model identifies five interdependent design levers - strategy, structure, processes, people, and rewards, with information as a cross-cutting coordination mechanism that binds them together. Galbraith's premise is that organisational effectiveness depends less on optimising any single element and more on achieving alignment across all five levers to support the strategic intent. This systems-based logic is especially relevant for firms undergoing rapid scaling, where imbalances among design elements (e.g., strategy outpacing structure, or misaligned incentives) can produce friction and inefficiency (Galbraith, 2014; Nadler & Tushman, 1997).

Strategy defines the direction and scope of the organisation and determines the design choices that follow. In the Star Model, strategy specifies how the firm intends to compete, what value proposition it pursues, and what kind of organisational capabilities are required to deliver it. For scaling firms, strategy articulates what should be replicated across markets and where adaptation is necessary. A scaling strategy may, for instance, prioritise rapid standardisation of the core product and customer acquisition model while permitting localisation of customer success or pricing to fit regional contexts. The strategic choices therefore define the balance between efficiency and responsiveness (Lawrence & Lorsch, 1967; Tippmann, Monaghan, & Reuber, 2023). In this study, RevOps is viewed as a structural response to such strategic imperatives, enabling firms to operationalise scalable commercial models that maintain coherence as international scope expands.

Structure represents the formal configuration of roles, reporting lines, and the degree of centralisation or decentralisation in decision-making. It defines how authority and accountability are distributed across organisational units (Mintzberg, 1979). For scaling

organisations, structure governs the locus of control, whether functions remain centralised at headquarters or dispersed across regions. Galbraith (2014) emphasises that structure must evolve as firms scale: a highly centralised model may facilitate control and efficiency in early stages, but decentralisation or hybrid structures become necessary to handle increased complexity and market heterogeneity. For RevOps, this implies designing governance that centralises core systems (e.g., CRM, data models) while enabling local flexibility in execution, a manifestation of the replication–adaptation balance (Tippmann et al., 2023).

Processes are the connective tissue of the organisation: the formal and informal workflows through which decisions are made, information is shared, and work is coordinated across boundaries (Galbraith, 2014). Effective processes enable integration - the ability of different units and functions to align around shared goals and shared information. In scaling firms, processes such as lead management, deal qualification, pipeline forecasting, and customer onboarding must become standardised and measurable to sustain efficiency as volume grows. Yet processes must also incorporate learning loops that capture local market insights and feed them back into system-wide improvement. Galbraith's model underscores that as interdependence increases, coordination must shift from hierarchy to process integration, an insight central to RevOps, which institutionalises cross-functional workflows that connect marketing, sales, and customer success.

The people dimension concerns talent acquisition, role design, competencies, and behavioural norms. It encompasses how individuals are selected, developed, and socialised to execute the organisation's strategy. As scaling firms expand, they encounter a shift from founder-centric intuition to professionalised role clarity and distributed leadership (Nadler & Tushman, 1997). Galbraith (2014) argues that design effectiveness depends on matching individual capabilities and mindsets to the structure and processes in place. In the scaling context, this means establishing role definitions that clarify ownership (for example, who owns renewals or pipeline quality), building analytical and operational capabilities, and embedding data literacy across commercial teams. RevOps illustrates this lever through its creation of specialised analytical and enablement roles that enhance decision quality and cross-functional collaboration.

Rewards and metrics align behaviour with strategic priorities by defining how performance is measured and incentivised. Galbraith (2014) maintains that without consistent metrics, cross-functional alignment is unsustainable: each function optimises for its own targets rather than shared outcomes. For scaling firms, this lever is crucial because misaligned incentives between marketing, sales, and customer success often create friction, information silos, and inconsistent customer experiences. The Star Model posits that well-aligned metrics act as behavioural control systems that replace the need for excessive supervision. In RevOps, this translates into unified revenue metrics (e.g., customer lifetime value, net retention, and funnel conversion rates) that promote end-to-end accountability across the customer lifecycle — an essential condition for scalable, predictable performance.

While not a separate lever, Galbraith (2014) treats information and decision rights as the glue connecting all other design dimensions. Organisations are information-processing systems: as they scale, the volume and diversity of information increase exponentially. Effective design requires information architectures and decision protocols that channel the right data to the right level of the organisation at the right time. This includes shared platforms, governance over data integrity, and escalation paths that resolve ambiguity without paralysing decision-making. In scaling contexts, the speed and quality of information flow determine how quickly firms can identify performance issues and adapt playbooks. RevOps directly operationalises this lever through centralised data infrastructure and defined governance processes, enabling consistent decision-making while maintaining agility.

Galbraith's (2014) Star Model thus provides a holistic framework for analysing how strategic intent is translated into operational reality through aligned design levers. Each lever - strategy, structure, processes, people, and rewards, plays a specific role, but the model's power lies in their interdependence. Misalignment among the levers, such as having scaling-oriented strategy without corresponding processes or metrics, creates friction and hinders performance (Nadler & Tushman, 1997). For firms scaling internationally, alignment becomes even more critical because complexity multiplies across geographies and cultures. By applying the Star Model, this study examines how RevOps serves as a design configuration that aligns these levers to create the coherence, agility, and repeatability required for international scaling.

2.2.2 Organisational design through the lens of Galbraith's star model

Galbraith's Star Model offers a structured analytic frame for this thesis: it both organises the empirical coding schema and guides theoretical interpretation. Practically, the model is used in three ways.

First, the Star Model clarifies mechanisms through which RevOps is hypothesised to affect scaling. For example, RevOps practices that standardise lead qualification (process) combined with a centralised data layer (information/structure) and aligned renewal incentives (rewards) should increase repeatability and predictability of unit economics when entering new markets. Conversely, RevOps governance that preserves local escalation paths (structure/process) can enable adaptation without undermining group standards, illustrating how alignment across levers produces the desired trade-off between replication and adaptation.

Second, the Star Model situates RevOps within broader theoretical debates (RBV; dynamic capabilities). By treating RevOps as a design configuration that bundles resources (data, tools, roles) and codifies routines (processes, metrics), the thesis argues that RevOps functions as a capability that may be rare and difficult to imitate when implemented coherently, thereby contributing to firm scalability and potentially to competitive advantage (Barney, 1991; Teece et al., 1997).

Finally, the contingency logic embedded in the Star Model informs the thesis' attention to boundary conditions: the same RevOps configuration will not suit every firm. The study therefore explicitly seeks to identify contingencies (product complexity, market heterogeneity, firm stage) that moderate the relationship between RevOps design and scaling outcomes, producing testable propositions that extend both Star Model applications and scaling theory.

2.3 Revenue operations as a form of organisational design

2.3.1 Conceptualising RevOps

Revenue Operations (RevOps) has emerged as a managerial configuration aimed at integrating customer-facing and revenue-generating functions, typically marketing, sales, and customer success - under a unified system of governance, data, and performance management. Although its terminology originates in practice, its underlying logic aligns closely with established organisational design theory. Specifically, RevOps can be understood as a design response to coordination failures that arise in scaling firms where cross-functional interdependence intensifies and information asymmetries accumulate. From this perspective, RevOps is not a new function per se but a meta-structure, a cross-functional coordination layer that governs how commercial subsystems interact, share information, and align towards collective performance outcomes.

The need for such integrative mechanisms has long been recognised in organisational theory. Lawrence and Lorsch (1967) demonstrated that effective organisations balance differentiation (specialisation of functions) with integration (mechanisms that ensure coordination across them). As firms scale, differentiation across commercial functions often increases - marketing manages demand generation, sales pursues conversion, and customer success ensures retention, creating siloed metrics, duplicated processes, and fragmented customer data. RevOps functions as an integrating mechanism that restores equilibrium between differentiation and integration, thereby enabling consistent execution of revenue processes across geographies and customer segments.

2.3.2 RevOps as a coordination and information-processing architecture

From an information-processing perspective, organisations must align their structures and systems with the amount of information uncertainty they face (Galbraith, 1973). Scaling amplifies uncertainty and interdependence: customer journeys extend across multiple touchpoints, and feedback cycles accelerate through digital channels. RevOps directly addresses these information-processing demands by establishing shared data infrastructures, common taxonomies, and unified performance dashboards. These mechanisms reduce information asymmetry and enable real-time decision-making across functions and

markets. In this sense, RevOps can be seen as an information-processing structure that expands the organisation's capacity to collect, synthesise, and act on market information, a core premise in Galbraith's (2014) theory of organisational design.

Furthermore, by embedding shared metrics and integrated planning processes, RevOps shifts coordination from sequential to reciprocal interdependence (Thompson, 1967). Rather than handoffs between functions, RevOps promotes continuous collaboration through integrated workflows and common accountability frameworks. This transition parallels Mintzberg's (1979) notion of "mutual adjustment" as the most sophisticated form of coordination in complex environments. Hence, RevOps embodies a contemporary organisational form in which coordination occurs through data transparency and shared governance rather than hierarchy.

2.3.3 RevOps as an enabling capability

RevOps can also be interpreted through the lens of the dynamic capabilities framework (Teece, Pisano, & Shuen, 1997). Dynamic capabilities concern an organisation's ability to integrate, build, and reconfigure internal and external competences to address rapidly changing environments. RevOps enables precisely such integration by institutionalising sensing (through unified analytics and feedback loops), seizing (through coordinated go-to-market actions), and reconfiguring (through continuous process improvement and data-driven learning). Through these mechanisms, RevOps supports the dynamic reconfiguration of commercial routines, a defining requirement for scalable international performance. Thus, RevOps functions as both a structural configuration and a capability system: it structures coordination while simultaneously enabling organisational learning and adaptation.

2.3.4 RevOps as a multidimensional design configuration

When interpreted through Galbraith's (2014) Star Model, RevOps can be conceptualised as a multidimensional organisational design configuration:

- Strategy: RevOps operationalises the strategic intent of achieving scalable, predictable revenue by aligning commercial functions to shared objectives.

- Structure: It creates cross-functional governance structures (e.g., revenue councils, integrated planning forums) that transcend functional boundaries while maintaining accountability.
- Processes: It codifies and integrates key revenue processes, such as lead management, forecasting, and customer lifecycle management - into unified workflows.
- People: It introduces specialised roles (e.g., operations analysts, enablement specialists, systems architects) that act as linking agents across functions.
- Rewards and metrics: It aligns incentives and KPIs around collective outcomes, such as customer lifetime value, retention, and recurring revenue growth.

This illustrates that RevOps embodies all five design levers of the Star Model, thereby fulfilling Galbraith's (2014) criterion of alignment between strategy, structure, and process to achieve coherence in complex environments. Importantly, RevOps does not replace existing functions; rather, it reconfigures the interfaces between them, making it an archetype of integrative organisational design suited to high-interdependence, data-rich settings.

2.3.5 RevOps as a response to the scaling challenge

Finally, RevOps can be understood as an organisational response to the scaling paradox described by Tippmann, Monaghan, and Reuber (2023): the tension between the need for process replication to achieve efficiency and the need for local adaptation to sustain relevance. By standardising data systems and governance mechanisms while allowing local flexibility in execution, RevOps provides an operational framework through which firms reconcile these dual imperatives. In doing so, it enables scaling firms to maintain strategic coherence and operational agility across international markets.

Taken together, these theoretical perspectives position RevOps as more than a set of operational practices; it represents a formal organisational design model that structures coordination, information processing, and learning across the commercial system. It integrates insights from classic and contemporary organisational design theories, including differentiation–integration (Lawrence & Lorsch, 1967), information processing (Galbraith, 1973, 2014), and dynamic capabilities (Teece et al., 1997), and applies them to the modern context of scaling digital-first firms. Thus, RevOps can be viewed as an emergent

organisational archetype that both reflects and advances the principles of adaptive, data-driven organisational design.

2.4 Revenue operations in the context of international scaling

International scaling represents a distinctive organisational challenge that requires firms to replicate proven business models efficiently while adapting to diverse and dynamic market contexts (Tippmann, Monaghan, & Reuber, 2023). Achieving this balance depends not only on strategic intent but on the design mechanisms through which coordination, learning, and control are operationalised across borders. The preceding literature highlights that scaling introduces heightened interdependence among organisational subsystems, particularly between customer-facing functions whose alignment determines the consistency and predictability of revenue generation (Autio, 2017). Yet, despite extensive theorisation of the scaling process, limited research has examined how organisational design enables firms to institutionalise such alignment at scale. It is within this conceptual gap that RevOps offers a novel explanatory lens.

RevOps can be interpreted as a design-based integration mechanism that addresses the structural and informational bottlenecks that typically emerge during international scaling. As firms expand, their commercial architectures often fragment local markets develop distinct processes, systems, and success metrics, undermining the coherence of global performance management. From an organisational design perspective, RevOps reconfigures these architectures by centralising data infrastructures, standardising key revenue processes, and instituting governance routines that span marketing, sales, and customer success (Galbraith, 2014). This allows the firm to maintain both global standardisation and local responsiveness, the very tension that defines scalable internationalisation (Teece, 2014; Tippmann et al., 2023).

Conceptually, the alignment between RevOps and scaling theory lies in their shared emphasis on repeatable learning systems. Scaling firms depend on the rapid replication of routines and feedback loops that convert local market learning into globally usable knowledge (Autio, 2017; Zahra, 2021). RevOps provides the structural foundation for such learning systems by integrating commercial data, creating shared performance

metrics, and formalising decision-making through common governance structures. In effect, RevOps transforms the commercial subsystem of the firm into a knowledge infrastructure capable of sustaining dynamic adaptation without forfeiting efficiency. This interpretation positions RevOps as an organisational capability that embodies the principles of dynamic capability theory, specifically, the integration and reconfiguration of revenue-generating activities in response to environmental heterogeneity (Teece et al., 1997).

Moreover, RevOps can be seen as a scaling-enabling coordination architecture that mitigates the paradox of distance inherent in international growth. As cross-border expansion increases organisational distance - geographic, cultural, and informational, RevOps acts as a bridging mechanism that ensures that strategic intent and operational execution remain synchronised. Its unifying role across data, incentives, and processes reduces the latency of information flow, thereby enhancing the organisation's ability to sense and respond to market signals in real time (Galbraith, 1973; Thompson, 1967). This function is particularly critical for digital-first firms whose business models rely on continuous customer engagement and rapid iteration.

Despite its increasing adoption in practice, RevOps remains largely unexplored within the academic discourse on international scaling and organisational design. The existing literature on scaling identifies integration and alignment as key determinants of sustained performance but does not explicate the design configurations that enable these outcomes in contemporary digital environments (Autio, 2017; Tippmann et al., 2023). Similarly, research on organisational design provides conceptual tools for understanding alignment, but empirical studies rarely investigate how these mechanisms are implemented within the commercial system of the firm. RevOps thus represents a theoretically significant and empirically underexplored configuration through which scaling firms translate strategic intent into operational coherence.

In summary, linking RevOps to international scaling highlights a missing connection between design theory and scaling practice. RevOps operationalises the principles of organisational design - alignment, integration, and information processing, within the most interdependent subsystem of the modern scaling firm: its revenue engine. By examining RevOps as a system of organisational design that supports international scaling, this study addresses a critical theoretical and empirical gap, offering a framework that explains how

firms build scalable growth infrastructures that balance global consistency with local responsiveness.

3 DATA AND METHODOLOGY

This chapter details the research design, data collection, and analytical strategy employed to investigate how organizational design, specifically RevOps, supports international scaling in high-growth software firms. Given the exploratory nature of the research and the need to build theory grounded in empirical data, a qualitative, interpretive approach utilizing the Gioia methodology was selected. This approach is not merely a procedural choice but a foundational alignment, enabling the rich, contextual understanding necessary to capture the complex interplay between organizational structure and international growth.

3.1 Interpretive qualitative research

The study adopts an interpretive qualitative research paradigm, which is uniquely suited for exploring the subjective meanings and social constructions that organizational actors attribute to their experiences (Cassell et al., 2018). Unlike positivist approaches, interpretivism prioritizes understanding phenomena through the participants' perspectives, recognizing the multiple constructed realities within a dynamic organizational context (Creswell & Race, 1999). This is critical for a study on RevOps and international scaling, as the function itself is an evolving construct, and its impact is heavily dependent on the context and interpretation of those who design and operate it.

The research is structured as an exploratory multiple case study. As Yin (2017) notes, case studies are ideal for investigating contemporary issues where the boundaries between the phenomenon (RevOps) and its context (international scaling in SaaS) are not clearly defined. The approach is specifically designed to answer the "how" and "why" questions central to this research, allowing for an in-depth exploration of the mechanisms and contextual conditions influencing organizational design for international scalability (Eisenhardt & Graebner, 2007). By focusing on multiple cases (the 15 organizations represented by the participants), the study leverages the strength of case studies to generate theory through inductive reasoning, particularly in this under-researched area (Eisenhardt, 1989).

3.2 Data collection and sampling strategy

The primary data source is semi-structured interviews with 15 senior executives and functional leaders (see Table 1 for participant details). This method was chosen for its optimal balance of consistency and flexibility. The semi-structured format ensures a consistent thematic structure across all interviews, grounded in the five dimensions of Galbraith's Star Model (strategy, structure, processes, rewards, and people), which provided a comprehensive lens for exploring organizational design (Galbraith, 2002). Simultaneously, the flexibility inherent in the approach allowed the researcher to probe deeply into emergent themes and context-specific insights, aligning with the interpretive paradigm of the study (Kvale & Brinkmann, 2009).

A purposive sampling strategy was employed to identify information-rich participants with deep expertise in organizational structuring during periods of high growth and internationalisation. Participants were selected based on three core criteria:

- Seniority: Held senior or executive-level roles (e.g., CRO, COO, VP of Strategy) with direct decision-making power over organizational structure.
- Experience: Led or directly participated in organizational (re)design efforts during growth phases.
- Context: Had 5+ years of experience in SaaS or digital-native companies with international scaling experience.

This rigorous selection process ensures that the data collected reflects the strategic and operational dimensions of the phenomenon from the perspective of knowledgeable agents, a prerequisite for the subsequent Gioia analysis (Gioia et al., 2013; Palinkas et al., 2015).

3.2.1 Interview structure

The interviews in this study were designed using a semi-structured format, organised around the five dimensions of Galbraith's Star Model (Appendix A): strategy, structure, processes, rewards, and people. This framework ensured a comprehensive exploration of how organisational design influences international growth within SaaS firms. Each interview began with introductory questions to establish the participant's background, company context, and involvement in organisational decisions. Core questions probed experiences in designing or adapting structures during international scaling efforts. Concluding questions encouraged participants to reflect on key lessons, challenges, and strategic insights. This structure allowed for consistent thematic focus across interviews while remaining flexible to follow emerging lines of inquiry, in line with interpretive qualitative research and the inductive approach underpinning the Gioia methodology (Gioia, Corley, & Hamilton, 2013).

Table 1 Interview Structure

Interview ID	Job title	Years of experience	Company Size	Market Presence	Industry sector	Interview Length (in minutes)
P1	Chief Revenue Officer (CRO)	15+	1,001–5,000	Global	SaaS	55
P2	VP of RevOps	10	201–500	EMEA	SaaS	68
P3	Director of GTM Operations	8	51–200	Europe	IT Consulting	47
P4	VP of Sales	12	501–1,000	Global	SaaS	66
P5	Head of Customer Success	9	201–500	Europe + North America	SaaS	65
P6	COO	20	5,001–10,000	Global	Enterprise Software	70

P7	VP of Marketing and Growth	11	201–500	EMEA	SaaS	48
P8	Regional Commercial Director	13	501–1,000	APAC	SaaS	54
P9	Director of International Expansion	10	201–500	Global	SaaS	58
P10	Chief Strategy Officer (CSO)	15	1,001–5,000	Global	Digital Health	70
P11	Head of RevOps	7	51–200	EMEA	SaaS	49
P12	VP of Sales Enablement	10	1,001–5,000	North America + Europe	IT Consulting	50
P13	RevOps Manager	6	201–500	Europe	SaaS	52
P14	Head of Commercial Strategy	9	501–1,000	Global	FinTech	58
P15	Director of Business Operations	10	51-200	APAC	SaaS	55

Note: Company size reflects employee count during participant's tenure. EMEA = Europe, Middle East, and Africa. APAC = Asia and Pacific region.

3.3 Data analysis: the Gioia methodology

The qualitative data were analysed using the Gioia methodology (Gioia et al., 2013). This rigorous, inductive framework is particularly well-suited for this study as it provides a structured process for moving from the rich, narrative data of the interviews to robust theoretical insights regarding an under-theorised phenomenon like RevOps in international scaling. The method maintains a clear audit trail, ensuring the emerging theory is firmly grounded in the empirical experiences of the participants.

The analytical process involved three systematic stages:

- First-order concepts (informant terms): The analysis began with the full transcription of all interviews. The researcher engaged in close, iterative reading to identify descriptive terms and phrases used by the informants themselves. These in vivo codes were grouped to form first-order concepts, preserving the emic (insider) perspective and ensuring fidelity to the participants' lived experiences.

- Second-order themes (researcher themes): As patterns and similarities emerged across the first-order concepts, the researcher began to abstract these into second-order themes. This interpretive phase shifted the analysis from surface-level description to deeper theoretical meaning, informed by organizational design literature, including contingency theory, dynamic capabilities, and Galbraith's Star Model.
- Aggregate dimensions (theoretical constructs): The second-order themes were then synthesised into a smaller set of three aggregate dimensions. These dimensions form the core theoretical constructs of the study, directly addressing the research question and providing the foundation for the emerging theoretical framework.

The relationship between these three stages is visually represented in the data structure diagram (presented in the Findings chapter), which demonstrates the analytical rigour and traceability from the raw data to the final theoretical model.

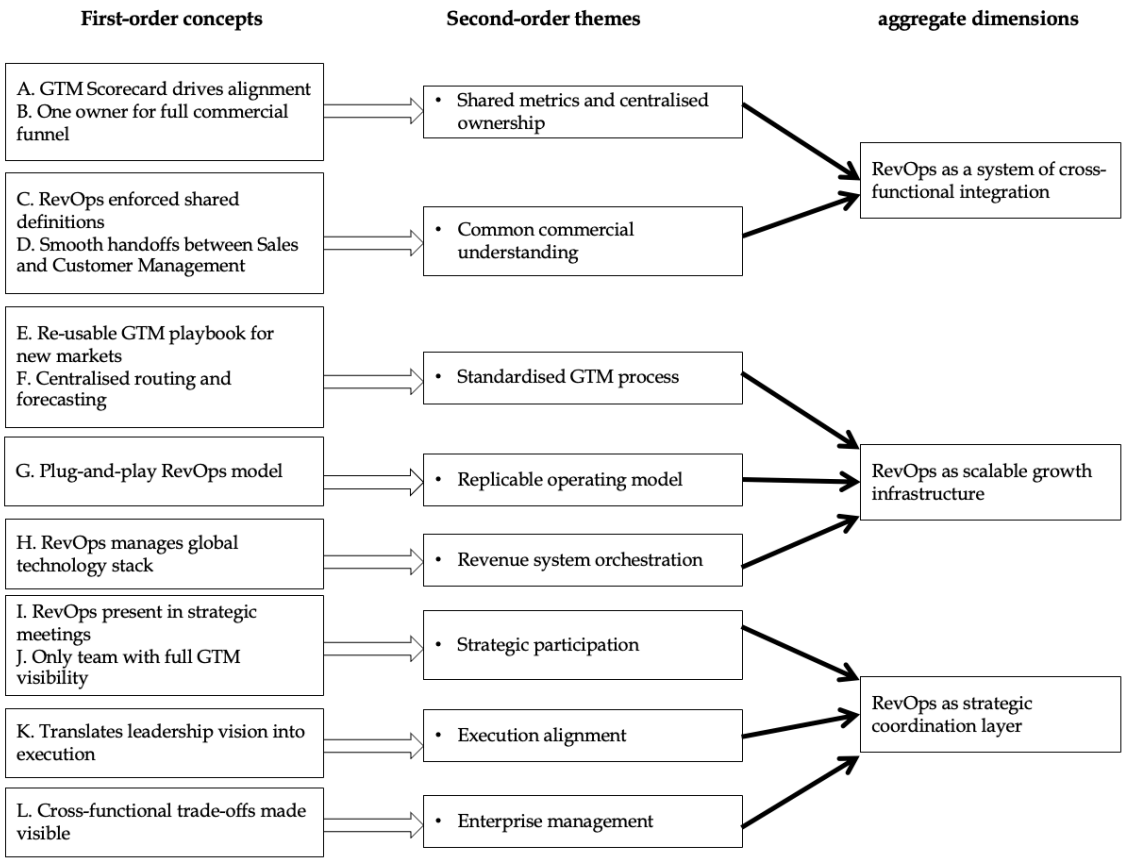
4 FINDINGS

This chapter presents the empirical findings derived from fifteen semi-structured interviews with senior executives and functional leaders across high-growth, digital-first firms. The purpose of the analysis was to explore how Revenue Operations (RevOps) functions as an organisational design model to support international scaling. The findings are structured according to the three aggregate dimensions that emerged from the Gioia analysis:

1. RevOps as a system of cross-functional integration,
2. RevOps as scalable growth infrastructure,
3. RevOps as a strategic coordination layer.

These dimensions collectively reveal how RevOps operates not merely as an operational function, but as an integrative and enabling architecture that allows digital-first organisations to scale coherently across markets. Each section blends informant evidence with interpretive commentary to demonstrate how participants' lived experiences shaped the theoretical insights of the study. (See Figure 1 for data structure.)

Figure 1 *Data structure*



4.1 RevOps as a system of cross-functional integration

Across all participating firms, executives depicted RevOps as a structural mechanism that binds together traditionally fragmented commercial functions - marketing, sales, and customer success, through shared definitions, metrics, and processes. This integrative capacity was repeatedly described as "the connective tissue" of the go-to-market (GTM) engine.

Table 2 *RevOps as a system of cross-functional integration*

Illustrative quotations	First-order concepts	Second-order themes
"The GTM scorecard sits with RevOps now, and it's the same set of numbers everyone is measured against. It's taken a lot of politics out of performance conversations." (P1) "Before RevOps, sales, marketing, and success had their own dashboards. Now there is one revenue board we all answer to." (P3)	GTM scorecard drives alignment	Shared metrics and centralised ownership

"It's not just about tracking pipeline. We have aligned OKRs for every GTM team and that's enforced through RevOps." (P5)		
"They don't just report on one part of the customer journey anymore. RevOps gives us full-funnel insight, from lead to churn." (P2) "When there's a single owner of the GTM data and reporting, you remove a lot of finger-pointing. That's what RevOps has brought." (P7)	One owner for full commercial funnel	
"We had to align definitions—like what counts as a qualified lead. RevOps made that happen across teams." (P9) "Everyone had their own idea of what MQL meant. RevOps forced the conversation and standardised it." (P11)	RevOps enforced shared definitions	Common commercial understanding
"RevOps brought order to the chaos. Sales knew what CS was doing, and handoffs became way smoother." (P10) "Before RevOps, customers would drop into a black hole after closing. Now there's a clear process handover." (P13) "The RevOps team mapped out the full customer journey, so now there's accountability across every touchpoint." (P6)	Smooth handoffs between Sales and Customer Management	

4.1.1 Shared metrics and centralised ownership

Prior to the establishment of RevOps, many organisations operated within functionally siloed reporting structures. Marketing, sales, and success teams often pursued different metrics of success, creating friction and mistrust. RevOps introduced a unified set of key performance indicators (KPIs) housed within a central GTM scorecard.

A Chief Revenue Officer explained, "*We finally stopped arguing over whose numbers were right. RevOps gave us one board, one set of KPIs, and suddenly performance*

conversations became about outcomes, not blame." (P1) Others emphasised the political relief this brought: meetings once dominated by justification and defensiveness became collaborative forums centred on performance improvement.

This convergence of measurement created what participants called "*a single version of truth*". Because RevOps owned the data definitions and reporting processes, no function could manipulate or reinterpret numbers to suit its narrative. A VP Marketing and Growth summarised, "*Before RevOps, each team had its own dashboard. Now there's one board we all answer to.*" (P7)

The analytical significance of this change lies in how shared metrics transformed the cultural logic of coordination. Alignment no longer depended on negotiation or goodwill but on a stable informational infrastructure that distributed accountability equitably across teams. In organisational-design terms, RevOps acts as a horizontal integrator, substituting relational coordination with structural alignment.

4.1.2 Common commercial understanding

Participants highlighted process standardisation as equally crucial to cross-functional integration. RevOps enforced clarity across the revenue funnel, establishing shared definitions for stages such as lead qualification or customer activation. A Head of Revenue Operations remarked, "*Everyone had their own idea of what 'qualified' meant. RevOps forced us to agree, document it, and stick to it."* (P11)

This shared vocabulary reduced coordination costs and prevented downstream friction. Once definitions were codified, RevOps mapped end-to-end hand-offs between teams, ensuring no stage of the customer journey was left ownerless. A Head of Commercial Strategy observed, "*Customers used to disappear into a black hole after closing. Now RevOps makes sure every hand-off is explicit."* (P14)

The interpretive insight here is that RevOps transforms tacit, relationship-based coordination into an explicit organisational grammar. By institutionalising process definitions and governance mechanisms, it stabilises collaboration across boundaries—vital in firms where growth velocity often exceeds structural maturity.

4.1.3 Interpretation

In sum, RevOps operates as an organisational integrator that replaces informal negotiation with formalised systems of measurement and process control. Participants' accounts demonstrate a shift from episodic, personality-driven alignment to enduring alignment through shared infrastructure. Theoretically, this resonates with Galbraith's (2002) notion of integration through information systems rather than hierarchy. For high-growth international firms, RevOps provides the coherence that prevents scale from degenerating into chaos.

4.2 RevOps as scalable growth infrastructure

Beyond integration, participants consistently portrayed RevOps as a foundational enabler of scalable, repeatable growth. In their view, RevOps institutionalises operating discipline and process modularity, allowing the organisation to replicate successful patterns across markets without losing efficiency or control.

Table 3 *RevOps as scalable growth infrastructure*

Illustrative quotations	First-order concepts	Second-order themes
"RevOps helped us replicate what worked in DACH for the Nordics in our commercial materials, it was highly replicable" (P3) "We didn't have to reinvent the wheel each time; the playbook was ready." (P5)	Re-usable GTM playbook for new markets	Standardised GTM process
"Leads go through a routing system owned by RevOps, it's automated and fair." (P14) "They implemented a global forecasting cadence; now execs have no surprises." (P13)	Centralised routing and forecasting	
"We really appreciated the clear operating procedures from lead to customer defined by RevOps; this really helps us manage the customer life cycle with clarity" (P10)	Plug-and-play RevOps model	Replicable operating model

"A business came into the company through our M&A, we were able to quickly adopt the commercial procedure that allowed us to quickly ramp up cross-sell, thanks to the very smart and clear RevOps framework" (P1)		
"RevOps owns Salesforce, the marketing platform, customer relationship management system, and customer success tools, it's all integrated." (P1) "Before, teams bought their own tools. Now RevOps centralises it so data's consistent." (P11)	RevOps manages global technology stack	Revenue system orchestration

4.2.1 Standardised GTM process

Executives frequently described how RevOps codified commercial knowledge into structured GTM playbooks. These documents captured sales stages, qualification criteria, governance cadences, and core metrics, serving as templates for new market launches.

A VP Sales noted, "*We didn't have to start from scratch every time we entered a region. RevOps had a full playbook ready—stages, KPIs, even enablement content.*" (P4) Another participant elaborated, "*We took what worked in DACH and replicated it for the Nordics. It was 80 per cent plug-and-play.*" (P5)

Such standardisation transformed market expansion from an artisanal process reliant on individual expertise into an institutional capability. Lessons learned in one geography became encoded knowledge accessible to all. In this sense, RevOps serves as the organisational memory of the commercial system, a repository that enables the firm to learn once and scale infinitely.

4.2.2 Replicable operating model

Participants also identified RevOps as the custodian of the firm's forecasting, routing, and governance mechanisms. By centralising lead distribution and pipeline management, RevOps ensured fairness, speed, and transparency across the GTM engine. "*Before*

RevOps, everything was manual, leads got lost, forecasts were guesswork. Now it's automated, data-driven, and global," explained one Regional Director (P8).

This centralisation not only enhanced efficiency but also provided a governance spine through which leadership could maintain control at scale. Forecasting cadences became uniform across regions, and deviations were visible in real time. A COO remarked, "*RevOps implemented a global forecasting rhythm. Now, no surprises—executives see the same data everywhere*." (P6)

4.2.3 Revenue system orchestration

Another defining feature of RevOps as infrastructure is technological orchestration. Participants repeatedly emphasised that RevOps managed the entire commercial tech stack, from CRM to marketing automation to customer-success tools, ensuring data and processes flowed seamlessly.

A Director of Business Operations summarised: "*Before, every region bought its own tools. Now RevOps integrates everything; one update rolls out globally overnight.*" (P15) A CRO added, "They didn't just add tools—they made them work together, so we finally see one picture." (P1)

This orchestration reduced duplication and delivered agility. RevOps' ownership of the stack turned technology from a collection of disconnected utilities into a coherent system of execution and insight. It also reinforced the perception of RevOps as the architect of scalability, capable of translating complexity into order.

4.2.4 Interpretation

Across interviews, the motif of repeatability recurred. RevOps was described as giving firms a "franchise model for growth", a modular, transferable GTM engine that could be deployed with minimal re-engineering. Theoretically, this embodies dynamic capabilities of replication: routines that enable organisations to reproduce effective configurations quickly.

By codifying playbooks, centralising data governance, and orchestrating technology, RevOps creates the infrastructure that transforms scale from a one-off effort into an

ongoing capability. It enables what participants described as institutional velocity: the capacity to grow fast without losing coherence.

4.3 RevOps as strategic coordination layer

The third aggregate dimension repositions RevOps beyond its operational roots. Participants consistently portrayed it as a strategic coordination layer that connects executive intent with field-level execution. As firms expanded across functions and geographies, RevOps provided the connective visibility and interpretive insight necessary to align strategic decisions with operational realities.

Table 4 *RevOps as strategic coordination layer*

Illustrative quotations	First-order concepts	Second-order themes
"We finally have one data model; everyone looks at the same dashboard." (P10) "When RevOps flags something, we listen, because it's very compelling because it's based on clear evidence and data points" (P11)	RevOps present in strategic meetings	Strategic participation
"We always find actionable insights from RevOps in terms of where out bottleneck is, especially areas where we normally do not have visibility into, for example, the correlation between sales activity level to the sales cycle length" (P13) "One of the key things we get from RevOps is the end-to-end GTM efficiency, we are able to easily diagnose issues to its roots, and take targeted actions" (P9)	Only team with full GTM visibility	
"RevOps turns boardroom strategy into day-to-day KPIs, that drives the incremental steps towards the business goals, we see this trickle-down effect very well" (P7) "They define what the pivot means operationally, targets, stages, headcount. RevOps helps us make balanced decisions especially when there are natural conflicts between costs and investments" (P12)	Translates leadership vision into execution	Execution alignment
"RevOps surfaces tensions early, if one region pushes too hard, others feel it. RevOps quantifies that	Cross-functional trade-offs made visible	Enterprise management

through clear and trackable data insights" (P2) "It used to be whoever shouted loudest got prioritised. Now it's data-based, it allowed us in the leadership make much better and informed decisions" (P9)		

4.3.1 Strategic participation

Executives credited RevOps with creating a shared analytical foundation for strategic decision-making. Prior to its emergence, leadership teams often relied on inconsistent reports generated by siloed departments, eroding trust in data. With RevOps controlling the commercial data model, this fragmentation was eliminated.

A CSO explained, "*Marketing and sales used to have different numbers. Now everyone looks at the same dashboard—it sounds trivial, but it changed everything.*" (P10) Another senior leader added, "*RevOps doesn't just deliver numbers; they tell us what the numbers mean and what questions to ask next.*" (P7)

This interpretive role elevated RevOps from data provider to strategic partner. Because it sits outside any single function, RevOps was perceived as analytically neutral and thus trusted. "*When RevOps raises a red flag, people listen—they don't have a political agenda*." noted one Director of International Expansion (P9).

Through this impartiality, RevOps became what one participant described as "the analytical conscience of the business" able to translate metrics into managerial insight.

4.3.2 Execution alignment

A persistent challenge across firms was ensuring that leadership vision translated into coherent execution. Many participants described a chronic "strategy–execution gap" whereby strategic initiatives failed to cascade into day-to-day operations. RevOps emerged as the mechanism that converted strategic direction into concrete processes, KPIs, and enablement routines.

A RevOps Manager commented, "*The boardroom slide means nothing if it doesn't change how people work. RevOps builds that bridge, they define what success looks like operationally*." (P13) Another participant recalled a strategic pivot towards mid-market customers: "*Leadership set the goal, but RevOps turned it into territories, quotas, and process changes. They made the shift real*." (P2)

Participants framed this translation function as both technical and social. RevOps had to interpret abstract strategic goals, engage stakeholders across teams, and reconfigure systems to embody the new direction. In this sense, RevOps acts as strategy's executor turning intent into infrastructure.

4.3.3 Enterprise management

As organisations scaled internationally, conflicting priorities inevitably surfaced between functions and regions. Participants identified RevOps as the entity that surfaced these tensions and framed them for resolution. "*If marketing doubles lead flow but SDRs are already at capacity, RevOps quantifies the impact and makes the trade-off visible*," explained one participant (P2).

Another recalled earlier chaos: "*It used to be whoever shouted loudest got prioritised. Now RevOps brings data, what it costs, what slows down, what we gain. Decisions are evidence-based*." (P9)

This mediating capability reflects RevOps' unique vantage point: it spans functions yet is not beholden to any, granting it legitimacy to arbitrate conflicting demands. It thus performs a system-stabilising function, enabling leadership to make informed decisions across competing constraints.

4.3.4 Interpretation

RevOps functions as the strategic nervous system of the commercial organisation, sensing signals across the funnel, interpreting them, and coordinating responses. It connects temporal horizons (strategy and execution) and spatial boundaries (functions and geographies).

Conceptually, this dimension aligns with theories of strategic integration capability (Lawrence & Lorsch, 1967; Galbraith, 2002). RevOps embodies this capability by institutionalising communication channels and analytical routines that ensure coherence between strategic intent and operational performance. Its emergence marks a shift from episodic alignment to continuous strategic orchestration, a hallmark of mature, internationally scaling firms.

4.4 Summary

Synthesising across the three dimensions, the empirical evidence positions RevOps as both a structural integrator and a strategic enabler of scalable growth.

At its foundation, RevOps aligns people and processes through shared definitions and unified data. Building on that base, it provides the infrastructure that allows rapid, repeatable expansion without sacrificing control. Finally, it connects insight to action, ensuring that strategic ambition translates into coordinated execution across borders and functions.

Collectively, these capabilities demonstrate that RevOps is not simply a department but an organisational design choice, a system architecture that institutionalises alignment, scalability, and adaptability. For high-growth digital firms, it represents a new operating logic: one in which data, process, and strategy are governed as an integrated whole.

5 DISCUSSIONS AND CONCLUSION

This chapter discusses the findings of the study in relation to the central research question: *How does Revenue Operations (RevOps) function as an organisational design model that enables international scaling in high-growth, digital-first firms?*

The discussion positions RevOps within the broader theoretical context of organisational design, extending Galbraith's Star Model to contemporary digital-era conditions. The chapter proceeds through the theoretical and practical implications of the study, outlines its limitations, suggests avenues for further research, and concludes with a synthesis of contributions.

5.1 Theoretical implications

This study advances organisational design theory by conceptualising Revenue Operations (RevOps) as an integrative coordination mechanism that operates within and across the five foundational elements of Galbraith's (1973, 1995) Star Model - strategy, structure, processes, people, and rewards.

Drawing from empirical evidence gathered from 15 senior-level professional operators, the research demonstrates that RevOps is not a discrete organisational unit but an embedded capability that interlaces these design components to enable scalable alignment across international contexts.

Cross-functional integration maps directly onto the structure and process elements of organisational design. RevOps serves as a lateral coordination mechanism (Galbraith, 1995), dissolving boundaries between marketing, sales, customer success, and operations. Interviewees described how unified key performance indicators, standardised hand-off routines, and shared data infrastructures replaced siloed coordination.

This aligns with research emphasising the role of integrative structures in reducing interfunctional conflict and enhancing systemic coherence (Lawrence & Lorsch, 1967; Burton et al., 2020). RevOps thus operationalises information-based integration, a shift from vertical hierarchy to horizontal coordination, enabling alignment without centralised control.

By codifying shared language and decision logic, RevOps creates what Eisenhardt and Santos (2002) term collective cognition: a common interpretive frame that underpins effective scaling.

Scalable infrastructure intersects most closely with people and rewards in Galbraith's model. Empirical evidence revealed that RevOps enables standardisation of go-to-market playbooks, formalisation of roles, and establishment of repeatable governance routines, thereby embedding scalability into the organisation's design architecture.

This reflects the notion of structural modularity (Sanchez & Mahoney, 1996), wherein routines are codified to be replicated across markets without loss of coherence. Moreover, RevOps mediates incentive alignment across commercial teams through transparent performance systems and shared KPIs.

By coordinating targets and reward mechanisms across functions, RevOps mitigates the motivational inconsistencies that often accompany scaling (Becker & Huselid, 2006). Through this systemic coherence, RevOps becomes the organisational infrastructure that sustains repeatability and accountability at scale.

Strategic coordination extends Galbraith's model by establishing a continuous feedback loop between strategy and all other design elements. RevOps functions as an organisational sensing mechanism that translates strategic intent into executable processes while transmitting performance insights back to leadership.

This aligns with concepts of dynamic alignment (Doz & Kosonen, 2010) and strategic ambidexterity (O'Reilly & Tushman, 2013), whereby organisations balance stability in execution with adaptability in direction. Participants emphasised that RevOps enables faster decision-making cycles by maintaining a unified data model and orchestrating communication flows across geographies and functions. Through this lens, RevOps operates as a meta-coordination system, an intermediary layer that integrates analytical capability with strategic governance. It embodies what Siggelkow (2001) describes as adaptive fit: the ability of organisational components to re-align continuously as the environment evolves.

By embedding RevOps within Galbraith's architecture, this research re-conceptualises the Star Model as a dynamic system rather than a static configuration. RevOps acts as connective tissue, ensuring that shifts in strategy trigger coherent adjustments across structure, processes, people, and rewards.

5.2 Practical implications

The findings hold significant practical implications for executives and revenue leaders designing organisations for international scaling. RevOps emerges not as an ancillary operational function but as a systemic enabler of agility, coherence, and strategic execution.

Many technology firms struggle with misalignment among commercial units. By institutionalising shared KPIs, standardising hand-offs, and embedding transparent data governance, RevOps dismantles functional silos and creates a single system of accountability. This shared infrastructure improves customer continuity, enhances data reliability, and strengthens cross-functional collaboration.

Scaling requires repeatable models that preserve efficiency across geographies. RevOps supports this by codifying go-to-market playbooks, automating forecasting, and orchestrating technology systems. These routines allow organisations to scale rapidly without re-engineering processes for each new market. In doing so, RevOps functions as the organisational memory that stores and transfers successful practices across contexts.

RevOps' role as a strategic coordination layer enables leadership to cascade priorities, monitor performance, and adapt plans dynamically. Its cross-functional vantage point allows it to translate strategic objectives into operational metrics and highlight trade-offs between regions or functions. Consequently, RevOps enhances strategic clarity and ensures that scaling efforts remain anchored in coherent execution.

RevOps also strengthens organisational responsiveness by creating fast feedback loops and predictive insights. Because it integrates commercial data systems, RevOps can identify friction points early and support evidence-based scenario planning. This agility is crucial for international scaling, where environmental uncertainty and market variation require continual recalibration.

Implementing RevOps demands leaders who possess analytical fluency and integrative thinking. Organisations should invest in developing professionals who can bridge commercial, operational, and technological domains. Career mobility across RevOps, finance, and product operations can cultivate this hybrid capability. At the leadership level, decision rights should reflect RevOps' integrative role, granting it influence in strategic planning and governance cycles.

Finally, RevOps entails a cultural shift towards transparency and shared ownership. Cross-functional rituals, such as quarterly business reviews and joint retrospectives, reinforce collective accountability. By promoting openness and continuous improvement, RevOps embeds alignment not only structurally but behaviourally.

5.3 Limitations

While the study provides a rich theoretical and empirical contribution, several limitations warrant acknowledgment.

First, as a qualitative interpretive study, the analysis prioritises depth over breadth. Although the Gioia methodology provided rigour, researcher interpretation may still influence theme formation (Creswell & Race, 1999). Findings should therefore be seen as analytically generalisable rather than statistically representative.

Second, the sample - fifteen senior professionals from high-growth, digital-first firms, they offer a strategic perspective that may underrepresent operational or frontline experiences. Different organisational maturities or industries may exhibit alternative configurations of RevOps.

Third, the focus on scaling technology-driven firms limits external validity for more traditional or domestic-only organisations. Contextual features such as global market entry, digital infrastructure, and decentralised teams shape the salience of RevOps.

Fourth, reliance on Galbraith's Star Model as the analytical frame may constrain interpretation within a structural-functional paradigm. Other theoretical lenses, such as sociotechnical systems, complexity theory, or network governance - might reveal complementary dimensions.

Finally, the positionality as a practitioner familiar with RevOps introduces potential bias. Reflexive practices, including documenting and peer debriefing, mitigated this risk, but complete neutrality cannot be assumed (Tracy, 2010).

5.4 Suggestions for further research

Future inquiry could deepen understanding of RevOps through several directions. Cross-contextual studies should examine how RevOps manifests in non-digital or traditional firms, exploring its adaptability to varied structural and cultural environments.

Comparative research across industries or firm sizes could identify contingencies affecting RevOps' effectiveness. Quantitative validation of the proposed framework could test relationships between RevOps practices and performance outcomes such as efficiency, revenue retention, or customer satisfaction. Integrating theoretical perspectives from dynamic capabilities (Teece et al., 1997), organisational ambidexterity (O'Reilly & Tushman, 2013), and systems thinking (Senge, 1990) may further explicate how RevOps supports adaptive learning and coordination.

Finally, micro-level studies could explore how RevOps reshapes power dynamics, leadership roles, and organisational identity, particularly as it operates through influence rather than formal authority.

5.5 Conclusion

This thesis has explored Revenue Operations (RevOps) as a contemporary organisational design model that enables international scaling in digital-first firms.

Through an interpretive, qualitative inquiry grounded in the Gioia methodology, the study generated a theory of RevOps as an embedded integrative system that connects strategic intent with operational execution. The findings reveal three interconnected dimensions that collectively position RevOps as a meta-structural capability. By institutionalising shared data, standardised routines, and adaptive feedback loops, RevOps provides the coherence and flexibility required for sustainable scaling.

The study extends Galbraith's Star Model by re-imagining RevOps as a dynamic, cross-cutting layer that aligns structure, processes, people, rewards, and strategy through continuous interaction. These reframing updates classical design theory for digital-era realities characterised by speed, decentralisation, and interdependence.

Practically, the research underscores RevOps' dual role as both a structural enabler and a cultural logic of alignment. It equips organisations with a scalable framework for maintaining coordination and accountability as they expand internationally. While bounded by its qualitative scope, the study offers a robust foundation for future empirical testing and conceptual refinement.

In an era defined by complexity and rapid change, RevOps represents more than a functional innovation, it constitutes a holistic organisational response that transforms how firms scale with clarity, cohesion, and strategic agility.

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APPENDIX A

